Developable Land Inventory

Technical Guidance

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Introduction

Purpose

This documentation provides technical guidance for preparing the municipal developable land inventory required for inclusion in Housing Growth Plans under Connecticut Public Act No. 25-1 of the November 2025 Special Session (PA 25-1). The inventory identifies developable land within a municipality for purposes of the Housing Growth Plan process, consistent with the definitions in Section 4(5) of PA 25-1. This guidance is intended as an analytical tool to support this exercise.

> **A note about developable land**
>
> Identifying land as developable does not obligate anyone to pursue development on that land, nor does identifying land as nondevelopable limit future development opportunities outside the context of the Housing Growth Plan process. The developable land inventory is not a permanent designation of a property's development potential. Rather, it is a necessary step in preparing a Housing Growth Plan under PA 25-1.

Audience

This document is intended for municipal staff, councils of government or regional planning agencies, and consultants responsible for compiling, reviewing, or applying data for developable land inventories as part of the Housing Growth Plan process.

Overview

This document explains the expected inputs and required outputs of the developable land inventory and provides technical guidance on recommended data resources and methodologies. It is designed to support a consistent, transparent, and replicable approach across municipalities. For additional context on the broader Housing Growth Plan framework and how the developable land inventory fits within that process, municipalities should refer to the Housing Growth Plan Guidance[link].

The sections that follow describe each statutory exclusion from developable land and the associated recommended datasets and methodologies, outline analysis methods for identifying vacant and potentially redevelopable land, and provide mapping guidance for assembling the final developable land inventory.

1 Required Outputs

Regarding the inventory of developable lands, the following outputs of this process are required as part of the Housing Growth Plan report:

1. A town-wide map showing the statutory constraints, vacant parcels, and parcels for potential redevelopment

2 Statutory Exclusions

Section 4(5) of PA 25-1 defines what developable land is and is not in the context of this planning process:

> *(5) "Developable land" means land, including any land owned by the state or a political subdivision of the state, including a municipality, that, as of January 1, 2026, can be feasibly developed or redeveloped into a residential development or a mixed-use development, as defined in section 8-13m of the general statutes, provided the feasibility of such development or redevelopment is based on commercially reasonable assumptions. "Developable land" does not include: (A) Land already committed to a public use or purpose, whether publicly or privately owned; (B) open space, parks and recreation areas that are dedicated to the public or subject to a recorded conservation easement; (C) land that is subject to an enforceable restriction on or prohibition of development, provided any such restriction or prohibition is not imposed by any zoning regulations or ordinance adopted by a municipality; (D) wetlands or watercourses, as defined in chapter 440 of the general statutes; and (E) areas of one-half or more acres of contiguous land that are unsuitable for development due to topographic features, such as steep slopes;*

This developable land inventory is a high-level description of land with a municipality that has opportunity for development or redevelopment of residential or mixed-use development.

Under the statute, several types of land are defined as areas that should be excluded from the developable land inventory for the purposes of Housing Growth Plans. The statutory exclusions identified in Section 4(5) of PA 25-1 are:

A. Land already committed to public use or purpose (public or private)
B. Open space, parks, and recreation areas dedicated to the public or protected by a conservation easement
C. Land subject to enforceable restrictions or prohibitions on development
D. Wetlands or watercourses, as defined in the Wetlands and Watercourses Act (CGS Chapter 440)
E. Contiguous land areas of 0.5 acres or more that are unsuitable for development due to steep slopes or other topographic conditions

In addition to incorporating these statutory constraints, the final inventory may also document vacant land and land with potential for redevelopment. These areas provide important context for analyses done in the later phases of the development of the Housing Growth Plans, which will assess capacity for future housing growth (see [link] for more information). Guidance for identifying and analyzing vacant and potentially redevelopable land is provided in Section X.

This section outlines each statutory constraint category, identifies recommended datasets for analysis, and provides technical guidance for preparing those datasets for inclusion in the final developable land inventory. The intent is to support consistent data preparation across municipalities and ensure that the resulting outputs meet the standards described in Section X[mapping standards section].

Workflow Overview

For each statutory constraint category, the workflow will generally proceed as follows:

1. Identify datasets that capture relevant land, parcel, or resource information associated with each category.
2. Filter datasets to the regional study area (i.e. municipality or planning region) and, where necessary, apply attribute queries or other selection criteria to isolate relevant features.
3. Review and verify selected areas for accuracy using available reference materials, including aerial imagery, local knowledge, municipal mapping resources, and other supporting datasets.

Finally, the land areas for each category will be compiled and symbolized in accordance with the mapping standards described in section X[mapping standards section]. The final map layouts will include the land area identified in this section. Inventories are recommended to include vacant land from section X and land for potential redevelopment from section X, since these components will be used in subsequent phases of the Housing Growth Plan analyses.

2.1 Land already committed to public use or purpose (public or private)

This category includes publicly or privately owned land dedicated to governmental, institutional, infrastructure, utility, transportation, educational, recreational, or other public-serving functions that limit or preclude development. Note that public ownership alone does not automatically indicate that land should be excluded from the developable land inventory. The land must be actively committed to, or reserved for, a public use or purpose.

Examples of land committed to public use or purpose include:

- Public schools and school campuses
- Municipal buildings and facilities (police, fire, emergency services, libraries, community centers, public works, transfer stations)
- Utility infrastructure and utility-owned land (water treatment plants, reservoirs, etc.)

- Transportation infrastructure (highways, airports, park-and-ride facilities)
- Cemeteries
- Active public parks and recreation complexes
- Institutional campuses serving a public purpose (hospitals, universities)
- Military or state-owned facilities
- Privately owned land permanently dedicated to a public function through easement, agreement, or operational use (e.g., a privately owned water supply reservoir subject to a public easement)

2.1.1 Recommended Datasets

There is no single comprehensive dataset of publicly committed land in Connecticut. The following sources, used in combination, should capture most qualifying parcels and land area. Some overlap across sources is expected, but each may also identify areas the others miss. See the "Technical Guidance" section below for more details about using, filtering, spatializing, and querying these datasets.

1. Local data
2. Parcel and CAMA Data
3. CT Education Directory
4. OpenStreetMap (OSM)

2.1.2 Technical Guidance

Local data

Utility parcel data, local zoning or public facilities layers, and local institutional datasets may be available from your municipality or utility providers.

Parcel and CAMA Data

We recommend starting with the parcel dataset. The CT GIS Office aggregates municipal parcel data annually. While locally published datasets may also be available, the statewide aggregation is publicly accessible through the CT Geodata Portal. This data is not edited or transformed by the CT GIS Office; questions about data quality or completeness should be directed to the local town assessor. For more information on CT parcel data aggregation, see the CT Geodata Portal page on parcels.

Links to datasets:

- Connecticut CAMA and Parcel Layer (CT Geodata Portal)
- 2025 Connecticut Parcel and CAMA Data (CT Open Data Portal)

We have completed a statewide queried feature layer as a hosted feature layer view on ArcGIS Online using the owner name and state use queries below. This can be used as a starting point for local analysis, or a new query analysis can be started on a full CAMA and parcel dataset.

Dataset: Connecticut Public Use Parcels (**CT Geodata Portal)

The following screening queries were developed for the statewide parcel dataset to identify parcels that are likely publicly committed based on owner name and land use description fields.

> ℹ Please note that terminology is not standardized across municipalities statewide; however, many jurisdictions use similar naming conventions and land use descriptions that can provide useful indicators for identifying parcels that may fit within a given category.

A. Owner Name Queries

Search the owner's name field ("Owner_Name") for terms including:

- "City of"
- "Town of"
- "State of Connecticut" or "State of"
- "U.S. Dept"
- "U.S. Dept" or "US Dept", "U S Government", "US Government", "U.S. Government"
- "Board of Ed"
- "Housing Authority" or "Housing Auth"
- "School District" or "School Dist"
- "Public Works"
- "Water Auth", "Sewer Auth", "Power Co", "National Rail", "Passenger Co"

Example query logic:

```
OWNER_NAME LIKE '%CITY OF%'

OR OWNER_NAME LIKE '%TOWN OF%'

OR OWNER_NAME LIKE '%STATE OF CONNECTICUT%'

OR OWNER_NAME LIKE '%U.S. DEPT%'
```

B. State Use and State Use Description Queries

Search use ("Use") or use description ("Use_Desc") fields for publicly oriented institutional and civic uses, including:

- "Post" for Postal Service (no false positives)
- "State" for state lands (no false positives)
- "Fed" for federal lands (1 false positive)
- "Education" or "Educ"
- "Library" or "Libr"
- Museum
- "Cemetery" or "Cemet"
- "Fire station" or "Fire"
- "Police" or "Pol"
- "Recreation"
- "Municipal" or "Munic"
- Government
- Public facility

Example query logic:

```
USE_DESC LIKE '%SCHOOL%'

OR USE_DESC LIKE '%LIBRARY%'

OR USE_DESC LIKE '%MUSEUM%'

OR USE_DESC LIKE '%HOSPITAL%'

OR USE_DESC LIKE '%CEMETERY%'
```

C. Rights-of-Way

Public and private rights-of-way (ROW) should generally be excluded from a developable land inventory, as these areas are reserved for transportation, access, or utility purposes and are not typically available for development.

No comprehensive statewide GIS dataset currently exists publicly that consistently identifies all rights-of-way across Connecticut. However, the statewide parcel dataset contains parcel records that can often be used to identify ROW areas through parcel attribute information.

Identifying Rights-of-Way in the Parcel Dataset

Rights-of-way may be identified using keyword searches within the [FIELD NAME] field of the parcel dataset. Common keywords may include:

- “ROW”
- “Right of Way”

Example query logic:

```
USE_DESC LIKE '%ROW%'

OR USE_DESC LIKE '%Right of Way%'
```

Because parcel data are compiled from municipal assessor records, terminology and attribute completeness vary considerably across jurisdictions. As a result, some municipalities may not consistently identify rights-of-way using standardized naming conventions or parcel attributes.

Where ROW polygons are present but not clearly identified through attribute queries, additional review methods may be necessary, including:

- Visual inspection of parcel geometry and spatial patterns
- Comparison with roadway centerline or transportation datasets
- Review of aerial imagery or basemap data
- Identification of narrow linear parcels associated with transportation or utility corridors

In municipalities where dedicated ROW polygons are not included in the parcel dataset, approximate rights-of-way areas may be derived by comparing the municipal boundary polygon to the aggregate parcel coverage. In these cases, the unassigned or residual land area between mapped parcel polygons and the municipal boundary may represent public rights-of-way or other unmapped areas.

CT Education Directory

There is no publicly available statewide GIS dataset representing public school locations in Connecticut. However, the Connecticut State Department of Education (CSDE) maintains a tabular dataset containing the official listing of public educational organizations, including district name, school name, street address, municipality, and ZIP code information.

Dataset: Education Directory (CT Open Data Portal)

Because the dataset is provided in address form and does not contain spatial geometry, the records must first be spatialized through a geocoding process to generate point features representing individual school locations. Once geocoded, the resulting point dataset can be used to identify associated parcel polygons through a spatial selection or spatial join operation, whereby parcels containing or intersecting school point locations are selected.

Following the spatial selection process, identified parcels should be reviewed and verified using available parcel ownership and land use attributes. In many cases, qualifying school parcels can be confirmed based on ownership records indicating municipal, district, or other public ownership, and/or parcel use classifications identifying the property as a school, educational facility, or similar institutional use. Additional manual review may be necessary in situations where multiple parcels are associated with a single school campus or where ownership and land use information are ambiguous.

Geocoding references:

- Yale Center for Geospatial Solutions Lessons: **Geocoding**

Parcel Selection from Points Reference:

- [placeholder]

OpenStreetMap

OpenStreetMap (OSM) data may be used to identify features and land uses such as cemeteries, schools, libraries, parks, and other civic, recreational, or institutional facilities. OSM is a crowd-sourced geographic database maintained by volunteer contributors, and data completeness, positional accuracy, and attribute consistency can vary across locations. As a result, OSM should be used as a supplemental reference source to assist in feature identification and screening rather than as a primary authoritative dataset. Features identified through OSM should be reviewed and verified using authoritative GIS data, parcel information, aerial imagery, or other reliable sources where available.

2.2 Open space, parks, and recreation areas dedicated to the public or protected by a conservation easement

This category includes lands preserved for conservation, passive or active recreation, natural resource protection, or public enjoyment, where development is limited or prohibited by dedication or conservation restriction.

Examples include:

- Conservation areas and land trust properties
- Municipal, state, or federal parks
- Greenways and recreational trails
- Wildlife management areas
- Land subject to conservation easements
- Public beaches, boat launches, or recreational waterfront areas
- Agricultural preservation land protected through conservation programs

2.2.1 Recommended Datasets

There is no single comprehensive dataset of open space, parks, and recreation areas in Connecticut. The following sources, used in combination, should capture most qualifying parcels and land area. Some overlap across sources is expected, but each may also identify areas the others miss. See the “Technical Guidance” section below for more details about using, filtering, spatializing, and querying these datasets.

1. Local data
2. Land trust inventories
3. Parcel and CAMA data
4. CT DEEP Property
5. [CT DEEP Protected Open Space (2011)](#sec-ct-deep-protected-open-space-(2011)
6. CT DEEP Federal Open Space
7. CT DEEP 1997 Municipal and Private Open Space Property
8. CT Department of Agriculture Conservation Easements
9. USGS PAD-US

2.2.2 Technical Guidance

Local data

Utility parcel data, local zoning or public facilities layers, and local institutional datasets may be available from your municipality or utility providers.

Land trust inventories

Land owned or permanently protected by land trusts should generally be considered protected open space and excluded from developable land inventories.No comprehensive statewide GIS dataset exists for land trust holdings in Connecticut.The Connecticut Land Conservation Council (CLCC) maintains a statewide directory of Connecticut land trusts that can be used to identify organizations operating within a municipality or region.

Source: CLCC Land Trust Inventory (CLCC)

The GIS Office Open Space Parcels layer [link] includes land trusts as identified through ownership from the parcel and CAMA dataset. See the Open Space Parcel and CAMA data section for more details.

Parcel and CAMA Data

We recommend starting with the parcel dataset. The CT GIS Office aggregates municipal parcel data annually. While locally published datasets may also be available, the statewide aggregation is publicly accessible through the CT Geodata Portal. This data is not edited or transformed by the CT GIS Office; questions about data quality or completeness should be directed to the local town assessor. For more information on CT parcel data aggregation, see the CT Geodata Portal page on parcels.

Links to datasets:

- Connecticut CAMA and Parcel Layer (CT Geodata Portal)
- 2025 Connecticut Parcel and CAMA Data (CT Open Data Portal)

We have completed a statewide queried filtered feature layer as a hosted feature layer view on AGOL using the queries above. This can be used as a starting point for local analysis, or a new query analysis can be started on a full CAMA and parcel.

Dataset: Connecticut Open Space Parcels (**CT Geodata Portal)

The following screening queries were developed for the statewide parcel dataset to identify parcels that are likely publicly committed based on owner name and land use description fields.

> ℹ Please note that terminology is not standardized across municipalities statewide; however, many jurisdictions use similar naming conventions and land use descriptions that can provide useful indicators for identifying parcels that may fit within a given category.

A. Owner and Co-Owner Queries

Search the owner (“Owner”) and co-owner (“Co_Owner”) fields for terms that contain conservation related ownerships, including:

- “Land trust”
- “Conservation” or “conservancy”
- “Land alliance”

Example query logic:

```
OWNER_NAME LIKE '%Land trust%'

OR OWNER_NAME LIKE '%Conservation%'

OR OWNER_NAME LIKE '%Land alliance%'
```

B. State Use Description Queries

Search the owner (“Owner”) and co-owner (“Co_Owner”) fields for terms that contain conservation related ownerships, including: Search state use description field (“State_Use_Description”) for open space and recreation codes, including:

- “490” (from PA 490)
- “Open” (for Open Space)

Example query logic:

```
OWNER_NAME LIKE '%Land trust%'

OR OWNER_NAME LIKE '%Conservation%'

OR OWNER_NAME LIKE '%Land alliance%'
```

CT DEEP Property

CT DEEP publishes a polygon feature layer representing property that compromises DEEP facilities such as state forests, parks, and wildlife management areas.

Dataset: DEEP Property (CT Geodata Portal)

> *DEEP Property is a polygon feature-based layer that includes all land owned in fee simple interest by the State of Connecticut Department of Energy and Environmental Protection. This layer is based on information that was collected and mapped at various scales and at different levels of accuracy. Generally, partial interests such as easements or development rights are not included in this layer. The exception is flood control areas, which may include permanent easements. Types of property in this layer include parks, forests, wildlife areas, flood control areas, scenic preserves, natural areas, historic reserves, DEEP owned waterbodies, water access sites and other miscellaneous properties. This layer is current and is updated as parcels are acquired by DEEP.*

This dataset is regularly maintained by CT DEEP and should be used to ensure that all properties identified through the parcel query in Section X.x are fully accounted for.

CT DEEP Protected Open Space (2011) {#sec-ct-deep-protected-open-space-(2011}

This was created as part of the CT DEEP Protected Open Space Mapping (POSM) Project in 2011. Not all CT towns are included in this inventory. See more detailed information about the contents of the dataset in the data description on the portal page.

Dataset: 2011 Protected Open Space Mapping Set (CT Geodata Portal)

This dataset has not been updated since 2011, so it should be used as reference only.

CT DEEP Federal Open Space

This dataset of Federal Open Space, published by CT DEEP, contains parcels of open space land owned by various agencies of the Federal government. It includes parcels owned in fee simple interest and partial interest, such as easements. Types of Federal open space include recreation areas created by the U. S. Army Corps of Engineers in the construction of flood control dams, such as Mansfield Hollow, Thomaston Dam, Colebrook River Lake and Hop Brook Lake; portions of the Appalachian Trail in northwest Connecticut owned by the National Park Service; and scenic and preservation easements, such as the scenic easements located along the Housatonic River in Kent, Cornwall and Canaan, and along the Connecticut River.

Dataset: Federal Open Space (CT Geodata Portal)

This layer has not been updated since 2004 and may not be accurate, so it should be used as reference only. For more information on this dataset, see the CT Eco Federal Open Space guide here: https://cteco.uconn.edu/guides/Federal_Open_Space.htm

CT DEEP 1997 Municipal and Private Open Space Property

1997 Municipal and Private Open Space Property, published by CT DEEP, is polygon feature-based data that includes land owned in fee simple interest by the municipalities, land trusts, and other private entities within the State of Connecticut.

Dataset: 1997 Municipal and Private Open Space (CT Geodata Portal)

Municipal and Private Open Space Property contains parcels owned by municipalities, land trusts and other private entities throughout the state. Generally, these parcels are open space and include schools, cemeteries, recreation, conservation and preservation land. This layer can be used with the Federal Property and DEP Property layers for a more comprehensive understanding of open space and recreation land throughout the State of Connecticut.

This layer has not been updated since 1997 and may not be accurate. For more accurate and current open space parcel data, please see the Protected Open Space and the Protected Open Space Phase 1 feature classes. This should be used as reference only.

CT Department of Agriculture Conservation Easements

Link to be added once published

Dataset:

USGS Protected Areas Database of the United States

The USGS Protected Areas Database of the United States (PAD-US) is a national geospatial dataset that inventories protected public lands and conservation areas across the United States. The dataset includes federal, state, local, and nonprofit conservation lands, as well as lands managed for recreation, natural resource protection, open space, and other protected uses.

Dataset: PAD-US Protection Mechanism Category (ArcGIS Online)

PAD-US can serve as an important reference dataset for identifying existing protected and open space lands that may qualify as constrained under this methodology. Because the dataset compiles information from many agencies and organizations, it should be used in conjunction with parcel data, local open space inventories, and other authoritative state or municipal sources.

The PAD-US program maintains published documentation and methodology describing data sources, compilation methods, protection classifications, and update processes. Users should review the official documentation to understand dataset limitations and interpretation considerations.

Use this layer as a supplemental reference source for open space and protected lands analysis.

2.3 Land subject to enforceable restrictions or prohibitions on development

This category includes land where development is legally restricted by deed, agreement, or other enforceable instruments.

Examples include:

- Deed-restricted properties

- [other?]

2.3.1 Guidance

To the extent that municipality-wide restriction data is digitially available, include it in the developable lands inventory at this stage. Detailed parcel-level research on specific restrictions will become important in later phases of the Housing Growth Plan when specific sites are being evaluated.

2.4 Wetlands or watercourses, as defined in the Wetlands and Watercourses Act (CGS Chapter 440)

Wetlands and watercourses are defined under the CT Wetlands and Watercourses Act (C.G.S. Chapter 440[link]) and include inland wetlands, watercourses, and related regulated areas subject to environmental protection and development limitations.

Connecticut wetlands and watercourses are defined as follows:

> *CT Inland Wetlands and Watercourse Act define inland wetlands by soil type. The soil types are poorly drained, very poorly drained, alluvial, and floodplain.*
>
> *The Act also defines the term watercourses very broadly to mean rivers, streams, brooks, waterways, lakes, ponds, marshes, swamps, bogs and all other bodies of water, natural or artificial, vernal or intermittent, public or private. Although the Act defines inland wetlands and watercourses separately, they occasionally may represent the same area as in the case of a marsh or swamp.*
>
> *Unlike inland wetlands which are defined by soil type and typically regulated by the municipalities of CT, tidal wetlands are defined in the Tidal Wetlands Act by their current or former tidal connection, and their capacity to support certain wetland vegetation. Tidal wetlands are regulated exclusively by the CT DEEP and not by municipal inland wetlands agencies.*
>
> CT DEEP, How are Inland Wetlands and Watercourses Defined in Connecticut?

2.4.1 Recommended Datasets

1. Soils Inland Wetland
2. High Resolution Tidal Marsh Datasets
3. Connecticut Hydrography Set
4. Local data

2.4.2 Technical Guidance

Soils Inland Wetland

This dataset from CT DEEP is derived from Connecticut SSURGO data and identifies wetland and non□wetland soils as defined by the Connecticut Inland Wetlands and Watercourses Act (C.G.S. Chapter 440).

Dataset: Soils Inland Wetland (CT Geodata Portal)

The Soil Survey Geographic Database (SSURGO) contains soil information compiled by the National Cooperative Soil Survey over the course of nearly a century, and the State of Connecticut defines inland wetlands based on soil characteristics. Under the Connecticut Inland Wetlands and Watercourses Act, wetland soils include any soil types designated as poorly drained, very poorly drained, alluvial, or floodplain by the National Cooperative Soil Survey, as periodically amended by the Natural Resources Conservation Service of the U.S. Department of Agriculture.

To delineate soil-defined inland wetlands, the CT DEEP Inland Wetland Soils feature layer should be queried using the “CTInlWet” attribute field, selecting records where the value equals “CT wetland.” The selected polygons represent soils meeting Connecticut’s regulatory wetland criteria and provide a statewide representation of inland wetland areas for mapping and analysis purposes. The resulting dataset may be included in the final map described in Section X.

High Resolution Tidal Marsh Datasets

Detailed tidal wetland mapping is available through CT DEEP and was developed using high-resolution lidar and aerial imagery survey of all the protected coastal marshland across the state of Connecticut. The data are available through the CT ECO geoSAP viewer and may be downloaded for GIS analysis.

Dataset: High Resolution Marsh Mapping (CT ECO)

> ℹ Municipalities located within Connecticut’s coastal areas should incorporate tidal wetland data into their developable land inventory to account for these regulated environmental resources.

Connecticut Hydrography Set

The CT National Hydrography Dataset (NHD) is published by CT DEEP as the Connecticut Hydrography Set, including both polygon and line features.

Dataset: Connecticut Hydrography Set (CT Geodata Portal)

At this time, the NHD remains the best available statewide geospatial dataset for identifying surface water features across Connecticut. As of October 1, 2023, the NHD was retired. NHD data will continue to be available but no longer maintained or updated. The most current hydrography data for Connecticut will eventually be provided through the USGS 3D Hydrography Program (3DHP), which is currently in development and will offer a higher□resolution surface water dataset. Once the 3DHP for Connecticut is completed and released, it will replace the NHD as the recommended dataset in this guidance.

As part of the Connecticut Hydrography Set, the Hydrography Poly layer includes polygon features that represent areas of water for rivers, streams, brooks, reservoirs, lakes, ponds, bays, coves, and harbors. Polygon features also depict inundation areas, marshes, dams, aqueducts, canals, tidal flats, shoals, rocks, channels, and island. For this analysis, the polygon features will give the best surface area cover estimation of surface water in CT.

> ℹ Although the NHD provides information locations of marshes, Connecticut inland wetlands are defined by soil type by statutes (C.G.S. Chapter 440) and this data should take priority over the NHD marshes category. See the Soils Inland Wetland[link] section for more details on inland wetlands data.

Local data

Datasets may be available from your municipality's inland wetlands agency. If available, local mapping can provide greater detail and more current information than statewide datasets.

2.5 Areas of 0.5 acres or more of contiguous land that are unsuitable for development due to topography (such as steep slopes)

Areas with unsuitable topography may not be reasonably available for development due to physical site constraints. While steep slopes are explicitly mentioned in the statutes and should be excluded from the developable land inventory, other considerations may include areas with significant soil erosion hazards and areas with shallow bedrock. While some of these areas may be technically developable, towns may consider excluding them from the developable land inventory for the purposes of this planning analysis.

2.5.1 Recommended Datasets

- Connecticut Steep Slope Areas
- All Soils Dataset
- Bedrock Geology Set

2.5.2 Technical Guidance

Connecticut Steep Slope Areas

This dataset was derived from the 2023 Digital Elevation Model (DEM) generated from the 2023 spring imagery and lidar capture. The steep slopes layer was developed from 10-foot and 2-foot per pixel DEM data and identifies areas classified as Moderate (10%–15%), Steep (15%–20%), and Very Steep (20%+) slopes. The feature layer is provided as polygons and includes fields identifying the municipality and COG. Detailed methodology for the development of this dataset is available on the CT Geodata Portal data page.

Dataset: Connecticut Steep Slope Areas (CT Geodata Portal)

We recommend using the 2-foot contour layer, as it provides the highest level of detail available. To use this layer, query the dataset for the area of interest (municipality or COG) and select the slope category or categories appropriate for the analysis. If alternative slope thresholds are desired, the DEM data and published methodology may be used to develop additional slope classifications.

The statute specifies "areas of 0.5 acres or more of contiguous land." Because contiguity is not explicitly defined and may be interpreted differently, this guidance does not prescribe a single methodology for identifying such areas. One reasonable approach is to use the steep slope polygons and filter for polygons greater than 0.5 acre in size. Since adjacent raster cells meeting the slope threshold are grouped into a single polygon during processing, the resulting polygons may serve as a useful proxy for contiguous areas. Municipalities may also use lidar-derived elevation data, contours, hillshade, or other terrain analyses to validate or refine the results based on local conditions.

All Soils Dataset

This dataset is a SSURGO-based soil dataset published by CT DEEP for Connecticut. It represents a digital soil survey and provides detailed soil geographic information developed through the National Cooperative Soil Survey program. It is generally the most detailed level of soil data available for statewide analysis. Additional information and metadata are available on the CT Geodata Portal data page.

Dataset: Soils All Soils (CT Geodata Portal)

To use this layer, refer to the soil attributes relevant to erosion hazard or related soil characteristics and query the dataset for the area of interest.

Bedrock Geology Set

This dataset is a polygon and line feature-based layer describing the solid material that underlies soil or other unconsolidated material across Connecticut. It represents mapped bedrock geology and is intended for use in understanding underlying geologic conditions at a statewide scale. Additional information is available on the CT Geodata Portal data page.

Dataset: Bedrock Geology Set (CT Geodata Portal)

To use this layer, query the dataset for the area of interest and review the mapped bedrock units in relation to shallow bedrock or other considerations.

See more information about Statewide Geologic Maps here: https://portal.ct.gov/DEEP/Geology/Statewide-Geologic-Maps

3 Identifying Vacant and Potential Land for Redevelopment

Beyond the statutory requirements, identifying vacant and potentially redevelopable parcels provides important context for the Housing Growth Plan and supports suitability analysis and further analyses in subsequent phases.

3.1 Vacant Parcels

Vacant parcels represent land that is either currently undeveloped or previously developed but now considered vacant and may present direct development opportunities. While no statewide dataset of vacant parcels exists, the statewide CAMA and parcel dataset can be queried to identify parcels labeled as vacant.

We have completed a statewide queried feature layer as a hosted feature layer view on ArcGIS Online. This can be used as a starting point for local analysis, or a new query analysis can be started on a full CAMA and parcel dataset.

Dataset: Connecticut Vacant Parcels (**CT Geodata Portal)

> ℹ Please note that terminology is not standardized across municipalities statewide; however, many jurisdictions use similar naming conventions and descriptions that can provide useful indicators for identifying parcels that may fit within a given category.

The following text-based queries were developed for the statewide parcel dataset to identify parcels that are likely vacant based on the state use code and state use description fields.

- State Use (is): “500”
- State Use Description (contains): “vac”

Example query logic:

```
STATE_USE IS '%500%'
OR STATE_USE_DESCRIPTION CONTAINS '%VAC%'
```

3.2 Potentially Redevelopable Land

Potentially redevelopable land consists of previously developed parcels with characteristics suggesting they may be underutilized or suitable for redevelopment.

Consider the following approaches:

- **Brownfields**: Previously contaminated or industrial sites undergoing or eligible for cleanup.
  - *[Analysis methodology to be provided]*
- **Land-to-improvement value ratio**: Analyze assessed land value to assessed improvements value in certain areas or districts to identify properties that may be underperforming (significantly higher than average land-to-improvements values)
  - *[Analysis methodology to be provided]*
- **Parcel size relative to district average:** Analyze parcel size by neighborhood or regulatory district to identify parcels that may be underutilized (significantly larger than the average) which may indicate an opportunity for infill development
  - *[Analysis methodology to be provided]*
- **Floor Area Ratio (FAR) analysis:** Analyze Floor Area Ratios by neighborhood or district to identify parcels that have significantly lower than average ratios which may indicate infill or redevelopment opportunities
  - *[Analysis methodology to be provided]*
- **Construction and renovation year clustering**: Analyze construction and renovation years to identify clusters of existing units in need of rehabilitation.
  - *[Analysis methodology to be provided]*

4 Creating the Map

The Developable Land Inventory should be presented as a single municipality-wide map. The map should clearly distinguish between different land categories using simple, accessible symbology.

4.1 Map Layers and Symbology

The final map should include the following layers.

Layer	Description	Recommended Symbology
Statutory Exclusions	Areas not considered developable under Section 4(5) of PA 25-1. All statutory exclusion datasets should be merged into a single layer.	Gray (`[hex code]`)
Vacant Areas	Areas identified as vacant in Section X.	`[hex code]`
Potentially Developable Land	Areas identified as potentially developable in Section X.	`[hex code]`
Basemap	A simple reference basemap used to provide geographic context, should not compete visually with the inventory layers.	Light, muted colors; avoid high-contrast imagery or dark backgrounds.

The colors selected for vacant and potentially developable land should provide sufficient visual contrast and remain distinguishable for users with color vision deficiencies. This is a recommended cartographic best practice that improves map readability and accessibility.

4.2 Required Map Elements

All Developable Land Inventory maps should include:

- Municipality-wide extent
- Clear map title
- Scale bar or representative fraction
- North arrow
- Legend identifying all mapped categories
- Data sources and preparation date (recommended)

5 Next Steps

The Developable Land Inventory feeds into subsequent phases of the Housing Growth Plan, including a suitability analysis, parcel and zoning district identification, and opportunities assessment for new development. Parcel-level detail, including deed restriction research and site-specific constraint verification, is addressed in those later phases.